Bringing the kids along: creating a new Kon-Tiki exhibition for both parents and children

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Abstract: Following the release of the motion picture "Kon-Tiki" in August 2012, the Kon-Tiki museum decided to upgrade its main display: the story of the Kon-Tiki raft sailing from Peru to Polynesia in 1947. We also wanted to involve children in the story, an aspect sorely missed at the museum.

Fish, sea creatures and tiny animals are found on almost every page in the best seller by Thor Heyerdahl, about the Kon-Tiki voyage. Amongst these interesting characters we found a tiny adventurous crab - nicknamed "Johannes" by the crew - who we choose to be the main character of the story and to communicate with the children. "Johannes" had to be given a form and we needed to create both a personality and supporting characters, with reference to the true story.

The extremely limited space available for this exhibition proved to be the main challenge. Independent displays for children, or separate activity areas could not be developed. The resulting exhibition had to somehow connect different age-groups in one flat display. We decided to develop a story-line which could be followed simultaneously by both children and adults so that families could pass through the exhibition experience together. The design meant that they could all follow the same story at a similar pace, through age-appropriate material set at different levels of the display, with connecting points now and again as they proceeded through the exhibition.

The impressive visual design of the Kon-Tiki movie led us to seek collaboration with designers involved with the film project, Artworx. A few years earlier Qvisten animation studio had developed a TV series based on the character of young Thor Heyerdahl, and we wanted their help in developing the children's interface. This presentation tells the story of the development of this new exhibition at the Kon-Tik Museum, and also presents some feedback from our visitors.

Keywords: exhibition, children, design

Introduction

On April 28th 1947 a balsa raft left the port town of Callao outside Lima in Peru. When, after 101 days at sea, it stranded on the reef on Raroia atoll in the Tuamotu island groups the Kon-Tiki raft had become the prop in the greatest sea-adventure of its day. Since 1950, 17 million people have seen the raft on display at the Kon-Tiki Museum. In August 2012, a motion picture dramatizing the story behind the expedition was released. It was the most expensive motion picture made in Norway to date and presented a new and fantastic visual image of the raft at sea.

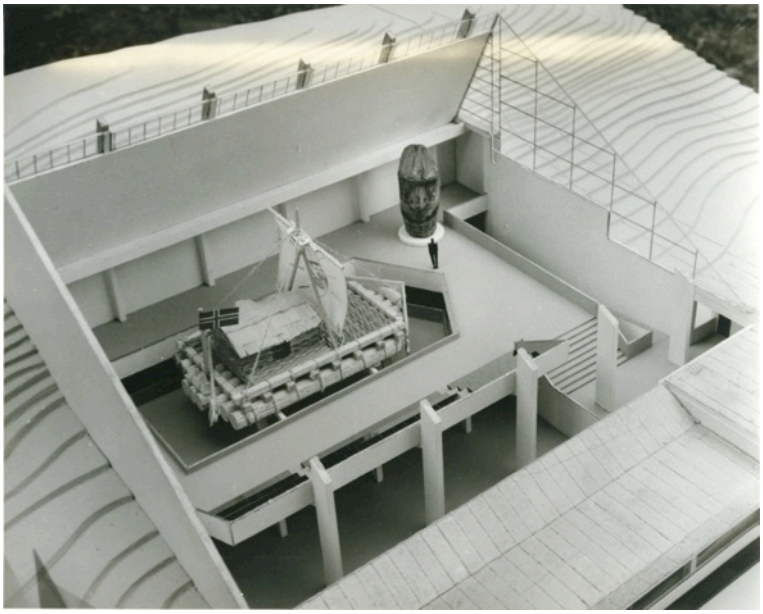


Fig. 1: Architectural model of the new permanent Kon-Tiki Museum built in 1956 (Courtesey of the Kon-Tiki Museum).

Earlier in 2012 the museum had discovered that the Kon-Tiki raft had to be restored. All ropes lashing the main logs together had to be replaced. The whole raft was to be taken apart and put back together again, by Olav Heyerdahl, the adventure grandson of Thor Heyerdahl. The timing with both restoration and a new movie was perfect, and the museum decided to upgrade its Kon-Tiki display. We decided on two main goals: first, we wanted to use the visual design of the new Kon-Tiki motion picture as inspiration; second, we wanted to involve children in the story.

Our decision to be inspired by the impressive visual design of the Kon-Tiki movie led us to seek collaboration with designers involved with the film project. Artworx, a small marketing and design firm that had developed a lot of the movie's marketing material seemed ideal. Our second goal, to involve children in the exhibition still had to be developed. A few years earlier Qvisten, an Oslo based animation studio that has made several animated children's movies had contacted the museum. They worked with developing a TV series based on the character of young Thor Heyerdahl and sought our help in providing ideas for the script. Now it was their turn to help us by developing ideas for a children’s interface within the exhibition.

The main design idea

The original Kon-Tiki Museum was a wooden building constructed in 1949. At the time no one believed that the Kon-Tiki raft could sustain enough interest for a permanent museum. However, with the ever-growing number of visitors a permanent museum building was constructed in 1956. In the season of 1984 visitor numbers peaked at 396,000. The Kon-Tiki Museum is a private foundation. Consequently the museum has to be run efficiently and exhibition space has always been restricted to a minimum.



Fig. 2: The Kon-Tiki hall as it appeared prior to 2007.

The Kon-Tiki raft is placed in the center of a square exhibition hall, level with the floor of the room. The front of the raft is facing the second museum hall housing the reed ship Ra II through open-walled architecture. Visitors are guided around the raft on narrow walk-ways with one side occupied by seats for tourists groups. This leaves only two wall-spaces for the exhibition with people moving by all the time. There is only between 2 to 2.5 meters from the wall to the glass railing surrounding the raft, and visitors have to view the exhibition at quite a close range.

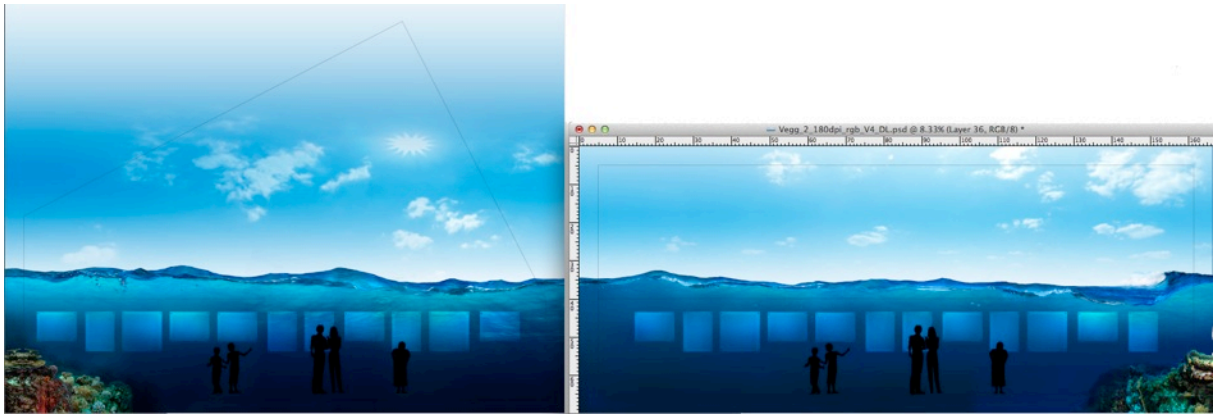


Fig. 3: First version of the background graphics (Courtesey of Artworx, Cory Grier).

In the 2012 motion picture the Kon-Tiki raft was surrounded by a visually impressive ocean; our principle design idea was to convey this image to our visitors. The art-director of Artworx, Cory Grier, constructed a composite picture/artwork of the Pacific with a giant wave in the center of one of the walls. Mounted 70x100 cm glass plates containing pictures on top and text on the bottom, made up the main display, which was placed below the waterline of the artwork. A professional story-teller wrote the text in collaboration with museum staff, and summaries in six languages were provided. A conscious design choice was to have most pictures in black-and-white to give the exhibition a realistic and retro look.



Fig. 4: An artistic rendering of the final exhibition display (Courtesey of Artworx, Cory Grier).

The children's interface

Our work with the children's interface for the new Kon-Tiki exhibition started with finding answers to some key questions:

- Should the children's interface be a separate exhibition or blended in to the general display?
- Which age-group should we target for the exhibition?
- Who should be the general voice for the exhibition?

The extremely limited space available for this exhibition proved the main challenge. Independent displays for children or separate activity areas could not be developed. As explained above, the Kon-Tiki room only has two tall walls for the exhibition with limited space between the walls and the visitors. In effect, the only realistic option was a flat display, two meters high, starting from the floor up. Only on the second wall could display cases be built to facilitate artifacts or interactive technology.

After some though discussions, we decided to develop one main display that occupied the space from 1-2 meters above the floor. This would be a traditional exhibition with individual stories framed by 70 by 100 cm panels of text with pictures sandwiched between two hung glass-plates. This left a space of 0-1 meter above the floor for a children's story. The main reason for adopting this plan was that we envisaged families experiencing the exhibition together. Adults and older children could read the text and watch the pictures; smaller children who could not reach up to read the main text would then be given an independent story they could follow. The two exhibitions connected at key points in the narrative, thus encouraging communication between adults, older children and younger children.

Johannes: the main character

Finding a general voice for the children's exhibition was the easiest issue to address and was our starting point. One of the most graphic stories from the Kon-Tiki voyage was the crew’s encounter with the largest fish in the ocean, a whale-shark. Since 1956 a whale-shark has been part of an underwater display in the museum basement, and a favorite with school children for five decades. The whale-shark was personified as "Tom" in a small children book produced by the museum. Today, Tom also visits the exhibits as a character in a special-made costume.

In light of this experience, an animal character seemed to be ideal as the lead voice drawing children into the Kon-Tiki story. However, we wanted a narrator that could follow the Kon-Tiki raft on the whole voyage and not only through the deep-ocean sailing. Fish, sea creatures and tiny animals are found on almost every page in the best seller on the Kon-Tiki voyage, written by Thor Heyerdahl. Several of these creatures were named by the crew. The most obvious candidate was Lorita, a colorful parrot given to the crew as a gift on leaving Callao. However, Lorita fell over board and was devoured by sharks. Not a fun story for kids.

An odd pair were the coach-roaches "Per" and "Lise". Per met an unfortunate end when he fell overboard. But Lise never could experience the underwater world. A colony of ants lived under the pillow of Erik Hesselberg, but for one reason or another they were never given pet names. The list of animals visiting or joining the Kon-Tiki expedition is long and diverse: dolphins, whales, porpoises, remoras, sardines, flying fish, yellow-fin tunas, dorados, squid, giant turtles, sword fish, sea stars,

clams, zebra-colored pilot fish, banana flies and fruit bugs. All these candidates either visited the raft for a short period only or lacked a personality that was to our liking. Choosing an animal that could experience both the underwater world of the ocean and who could interact with the people on the raft was our main criteria.

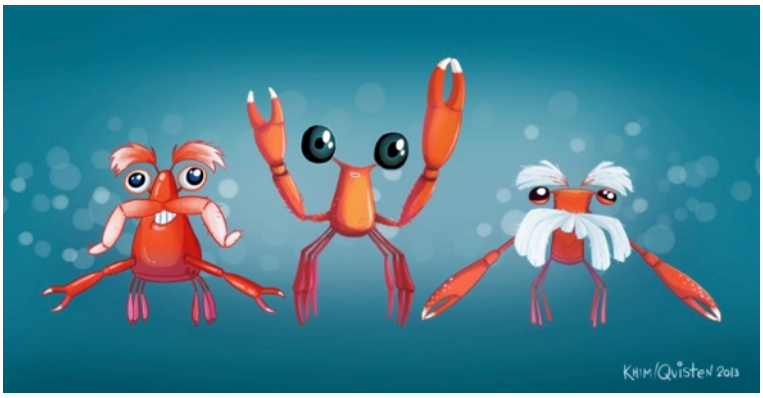


Fig. 5: First drafts of "Johannes" (Courtesey of Qvisten Animation, Khim Tengesdal).

On June 5th 1947 the following line is scribbled down in the diary: "Since we lost parrot our main pet has become a little brown crab with white design on back, that lives in little hole in one log near steersman's foot. When we bend down crab-named Johannes-runs out, and when he holds some biscuit crumbs, fish or canned meat between fingers Johannes comes and scratches it from us, then happily carries it to hole and starts eating by putting claws to mouth like a human. If the piece is too big Johannes puts it in hole first, then sits on top of it. Other crabs with different colours come out to look, but somehow Johannes has become our pet." Johannes seemed to have the perky personality of an adventurer. So, we decided to develop this tiny explorer into a character guiding children through the fantastic maritime story of the Kon-Tiki raft crossing the Pacific.



Fig. 6: Developing the character "Johannes" (Courtesey of Qvisten Animation, Khim Tengesdal).

Johannes is described as a brown or red-brown pelagic crab between a half and two inches. Our text writer, Holger Fangel, developed a character of an old Peruvian sénor with a big heart and a big ego to match. We decided quickly that Johannes had accidentally drifted past the Kon-Tiki raft on one of his own adventures when he decided to visit this strange vessel, made friends with the crew and shared their adventures, hardship and theory of South Americans colonizing the Pacific Islands,- an animal equal to Thor Heyerdahl. It was as much his expedition as it was anyone else's. In the end he met a nice female crab on Raroia and settled in this South Sea paradise. Some of the other animals

encountered in the book about the Kon-Tiki expedition were used as side-shows, so that the story may be developed into a children's book in the future.



Fig. 7: Mood-board of the final version of "Johannes", who has become a bit fatter (Courtesey of Qvisten Animation, Khim Tengesdal).

Developing the display

The main debates on the design of the display centered on two connected questions: Should the story be told in a traditional continuous display or should we adopt a cartoon-styled narrative with a mosaic of individually colored panels? Should it be a traditional text-centered display or should we develop the exhibition exclusively for children who can not yet read?



Fig. 8: First draft of the children's display (Courtesey of Qvisten Animation, Khim Tengesdal).

The main argument for making a cartoon-based storyline for non-literate children was that the height of the center of the display would be lower than the average height of literate children. On the other hand, developing a cartoon would be more expensive and labor intensive, in that we needed to develop the story further and put much more resources into drawing. In the end a continuous design with illustrated episodes incorporating small pieces of texts, but with a somewhat longer introductory text was adopted. The main reasons for this were time and resources, although it was also embraced by the creative team.

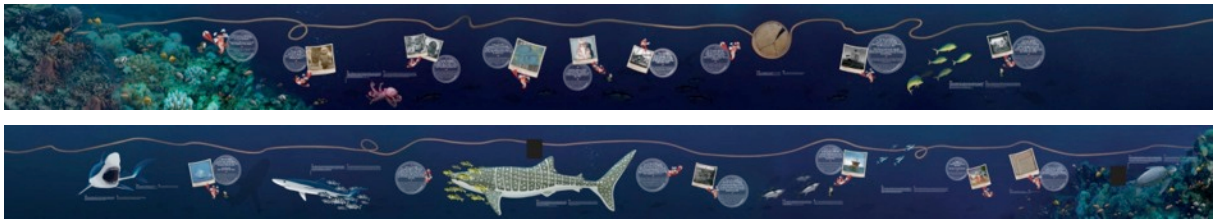


Fig. 9: Final version of the children's display, wall one and two (Courtesey of Artworx, Cory Grier).

Two strategies were adopted to connect the children's exhibition with the main display. First, Johannes, the main narrator, was equipped with a camera. Pictures used to tell the main story were presented, in different versions, as snapshots taken by Johannes during "his expedition". Second, we

also had four connecting stories, where the same story was told in both exhibitions at the same physical location. Thus, adults and children could experience the same narrative and "exchange" information and viewpoints.

Feedback

Aftenposten, one of Norway's leading newspapers, reviewed museum display in an article series during the summer of 2013. The Kon-Tiki Museum got a rather terrible review on how we had (not) adopted our exhibitions for children. Apparently, we did not have any activities or displays specially adapted to this group of visitors. Needless to say I confronted the desk and they said that they had not seen the children's display placed underneath our main exhibition of the Kon-Tiki expedition. It seemed that our choice of developing a display for children on the 0-1 m space beneath the main display had been flawed. However, the two journalists had also not seen our new 6.5 m long and 2 m high video screen created as part of the underwater-life-display in the basement underneath the Kon-Tiki raft. This is probably the largest continuous run video exhibition display in a Norwegian museum. My conclusion: the journalists had not spent enough much time in the museum. Their review, to say the least, was not very factual and objective. We had to rely on feedback from our regular visitors instead.

A customer satisfaction survey is conducted every two years at the museum. Customers rate each exhibition on a variety of factors: how the story is told; the lighting of the exhibition; range of artifacts; etc… on a scale of 1-5. The new Kon-Tiki exhibition, as a total experience, scored 0.8 points higher than previously and are repeatedly our most liked exhibition.

Personally, I can see that visitors spend more time around the Kon-Tiki than they used to. Partly because the raft itself is restored and made more visible; partly because the exhibition has almost doubled in size with more text and more artifacts; but also because families spend time talking to each other as they pass along the exhibition. It is particularly rewarding to see that parents (and many grand-parents) spend time with their youngest children explaining parts of the story to them. Sometimes we also see the older children reading out the story of the children's display to their younger siblings.

It is also very easy to conclude that spending more time passing along the Kon-Tiki exhibition is made possible because the youngest children are given something to explore on their own terms. They do not drag and hurry their parents along in the same manner as before we opened the new exhibition. Simply, it takes a longer time for the kids are more engaged. The parents can bring their children along, while they themselves get to read the story.



Fig. 10: "Johannes" with the lady-crab he met on Raroia (Courtesey of Qvisten Animation, Khim Tengesdal).

We have also received some negative feedback. The first point is that we should have more tactile elements in the children's display. These elements were planned, but have not yet been installed. The second point is that we have a lot of factual information about sea-life in the display, but some of these are put too close to the floor, making them hard, if not impossible, to read. In future upgrades we will angle the lower end of the children's display 10 cm out from the wall so it will become easier to experience all the drawings and information in this area.



Fig. 11: A view of the final exhibition (Courtesey of Artworx, Cory Grier).